

REIMAGINING TOURISM

Helicopters in the tourism sector began in earnest due to the pilgrimage to the Vaishno Devi temple

One major reason for the rising popularity of heli tourism is pilgrimage, particularly the trip to the Vaishno Devi temple in Jammu and Kashmir. “The passageway leading to the temple has always been risky, and many used to avoid going on the pilgrimage because the task was difficult. That is where the helicopter services truly took off. Nowadays, taking a helicopter to reach the temple has become very common and many private operators work in this domain,” says Captain Uday Geli, President (Western region) of industry body Rotary Wing Society of India, adding that a supportive regulatory environment has also helped.

Now, one can also take a chopper on the famous Char Dham Yatra—comprising the holy sites of Kedarnath, Badrinath, Gangotri, and Yamunotri—in the mountains of Uttarakhand. “Badrinath is a difficult place, and during winters, if there is heavy snowfall, it becomes even more difficult to traverse. That is why we operate our helicopter services for tourists,” says Rohit Mathur, a journalist-turned-entrepreneur whose company, Heritage Aviation, is among the leading players in the heli tourism segment.

Heritage offers dedicated tour packages at subsidised rates under the government’s UDAN scheme in three places in Uttarakhand—Haldwani, Pithoragarh, and Champawat. “If you use the helicopters operating under this scheme from us, the cost [for a single trip], say from Haldwani, is now as low as ₹4,000,” says Mathur.

Looking to experience the



UP, UP, AND AWAY

COMPANY	ROUTE	PRICE
> Heritage Aviation	Char Dham Yatra (Yamunotri, Gangotri, Kedarnath, Badrinath)	₹ 1.99 lakh
> Heritage Aviation	Haldwani to Munsyari	₹ 4,000
> Heritage Aviation	Haldwani to Pithoragarh	₹ 4,000
> Udan Aviation	Char Dham Yatra	₹ 1.98 lakh
> Udan Aviation	Do Dham Yatra (Dehradun-Kedarnath-Badrinath)	₹ 1.15 lakh
> Kerala Tourism's Sky Escapes	Kochi-Munnar-Kochi	₹ 3.30 lakh (two days, one night)
> Gautam and Gautam Group	Dehradun-Pithoragarh-Dehradun	₹ 8,699 one way
> Arihant Helicopter Services	Do Dham Yatra (Dehradun-Kedarnath-Badrinath)	₹ 90,000
> Arihant Helicopter Services	Char Dham (Yamunotri, Gangotri, Kedarnath and Badrinath)	₹ 1.80 lakh

NOTE PRICES ARE PER PERSON SOURCE COMPANIES' WEBSITES



▲ **TRAVEL IN STYLE** Heritage Aviation flies its tourists to three places in Uttarakhand—Haldwani, Pithoragarh, and Champawat